

Master Forever

Taseer reclaims his cultural inheritance through his translation of Manto

By Gillian Wright



MANTO: SELECTED STORIES

Translated by AATISH TASEER

Random House

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 136

Saadat Hasan Manto is undoubtedly the master of the Urdu short story. No one in India or Pakistan has bettered his ability to create a world in a few well chosen words and to end each tale with an unexpected twist. True, reading Manto sometimes feels like being battered with a sledgehammer. He lays bare stark and shocking realities and his characters, mostly from the fringes of society, can face hor-

rific situations. His friend and fellow writer, Ismat Chughtai, summed his work up by saying, "From the jilted squalor and refuse of life, he picks out pearls."

Some of his stories are set in Bombay, and some in Punjab, his home state. Growing up in Amritsar in the years after the Jallianwala Bagh massacre, Manto's sympathies were with the revolutionaries and with Bhagat Singh. In one story in this collection, *For Freedom*, he is deeply critical of a political saint, portrayed very much like Mahatma Gandhi, who links sexual restraint to the freedom struggle. Restraint was never something Manto aspired to.

His stories have not dated. Partition may have taken place over 60 years ago but brutalities still take place in times of conflict around the world. This collection contains *Khol Do*, one of Manto's most celebrated Partition stories, which describes how a girl is raped by her so-called protectors. Its publication led to one of the obscenity charges Manto faced after he

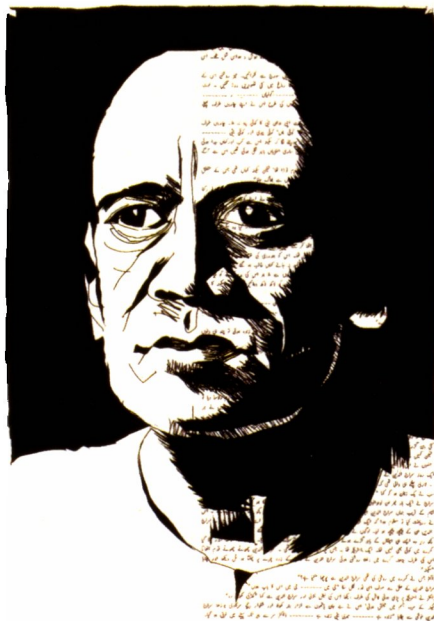
migrated to Pakistan. But the translator of this collection, Aatish Taseer, has deliberately chosen not to concentrate on Partition. He aims at a wider selection from Manto's over 200 stories. He includes one about a child prostitute, another about a servant discovering sex, and another about a starlet in the Bombay film industry—the industry where Manto worked before Independence. In fact, the central characters of most of the stories in this collection are women.

Taseer, the Indian descendent of a renowned Urdu poet, has in a way reclaimed his inheritance by learning the Urdu script and

translating Manto. In his introduction, Taseer pays tribute to his teacher, which is fitting, and to the rich but diminished tradition of Urdu in India. Besides this, he gives a lively account of Manto and his work. Unfortunately, Taseer also feels obliged to rubbish Khalid Hasan, whose highly readable translations of Manto have been published earlier. Dubbing Hasan a "well meaning journalist" is really damning with faint praise, and calling his translations "synopses" is downright insulting. Taseer probably does stick more closely to the original than Hasan, but he would

have been much better occupied extracting the motes from his own eye than commenting on any plank in Hasan's. A random comparison of the translations in this book with Manto's original stories shows that Taseer too has taken liberties.

However, any book of Manto's is unmissable. As he wrote in his own epitaph, with pride and a touch of humour, "Under tons of earth he lies, wondering if he is a greater short story writer than God."



SAURABH SINGH



THE TERRORIST IN SEARCH OF HUMANITY

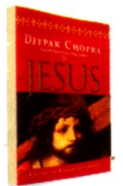
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